The Dilemma of Social Change: When Caring Causes Harm

I have visited many aquariums and marine sites, and whale watching has always felt a little complicated to me. People go out to see whales because they care about marine life, yet getting close enough to watch them can also disturb them. I started wondering whether our desire to experience marine life can sometimes become part of the problem. Hardcastle et al.'s (2025) research, discussed in the lecture, made me think about this in terms of **when** we choose to act.

Hardcastle et al. (2025) discuss sociotemporalities, or how our understanding of time shapes when change seems possible or necessary. In their interviews about targeted advertising, participants described a "pacing problem", where technological innovation moves faster than regulation. One participant suggested that intervention could wait until the industry matures. I found this interesting because it showed me how easily waiting can become a reasonable response, even when a problem is already happening.

I see a similar tension in whale watching. It is often presented as a sustainable alternative to extractive uses of marine life and can help people learn about conservation. However, vessels can disrupt cetacean behaviours such as travelling and resting (Puszka, Shimeta and Robb, 2021), while these effects can accumulate and be difficult to assess (New et al., 2015). Waiting for undeniable evidence before acting is difficult to justify because, by then, some harm has already occurred. At the same time, overly broad restrictions could affect livelihoods and opportunities to experience marine life. The harder question is therefore how much disturbance we are willing to accept.

This also changed how I think about effective protest. I used to think of protest mainly as raising awareness and getting people to care. But awareness does not necessarily change behaviour. Puszka, Shimeta and Robb (2021) found behavioural disturbance and low compliance with vessel-approach regulations in Australian waters, suggesting that rules only matter when they are enforced.

Ultimately, I have realised that timing is an ethical choice. I used to think waiting for more evidence was always responsible. Now I wonder whether waiting can sometimes become an excuse for doing nothing. If the "right time" is always later, who benefits from that delay? In our group project, I want to focus on protest that turns concern for marine life into enforceable action, rather than simply encouraging people to care.

References:

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